Free speech serves many ends. It is essential to our democratic form of government, see, *e. g.*, *Garrison* v. *Louisiana*, 379 U. S. 64, 74–75 (1964), and it furthers the search for truth, see, *e. g.*, *Thornhill* v. *Alabama*, 310 U. S. 88, 95 (1940). Whenever the Federal Government or a State prevents individuals from saying what they think on important matters or compels them to voice ideas with which they disagree, it undermines these ends.

When speech is compelled, however, additional damage is done. In that situation, individuals are coerced into betraying their convictions. Forcing free and independent individuals to endorse ideas they find objectionable is always demeaning, and for this reason, one of our landmark free speech cases said that a law commanding "involuntary affirmation" of objected-to beliefs would require "even more immediate and urgent grounds" than a law demanding silence. *Barnette*, *supra*, at 633; see also *Riley*, *supra*, at 796–797 (rejecting "deferential test" for compelled speech claims).

Compelling a person to *subsidize* the speech of other private speakers raises similar First Amendment concerns. *Knox*, *supra*, at 309; *United States* v. *United Foods*, *Inc.*, 533 U. S. 405, 410 (2001); *Abood*, *supra*, at 222, 234–235. As Jefferson famously put it, "to compel a man to furnish contributions of money for the propagation of opinions which he disbelieves and abhors is sinful and tyrannical." A Bill for Establishing Religious Freedom, in 2 Papers of Thomas Jefferson 545 (J. Boyd ed. 1950) (emphasis deleted and footnote omitted); see also *Hudson*, 475 U. S., at 305, n. 15. We have therefore recognized that a "'significant impingement on First Amendment rights'" occurs when public employees are required to provide financial support for a union that "takes many positions during collective bargaining that have powerful political and civic consequences." *Knox*, *supra*, at 310–311 (quoting *Ellis* v. *Railway Clerks*, 466 U. S. 435, 455 (1984)).